

High performance cars make a beeline for India

Exciting times to be a petrolhead, despite the Government's call to go green.

Souvik Das | souvik@digit.in

SKODA OCTAVIA RS

The Skoda Octavia RS will not make you gape in awe. In fact, once you see it on road, you may not even recognise it as a high performance beast. After all, it looks exactly like the standard Skoda Octavia, which, despite looking quite



smart, is not a pivotal head-turner. But, the advent of the Skoda Octavia RS is a crucial juncture for the Indian automotive industry.

To talk of the car, the Octavia RS has a 227bhp engine mated to 6-speed manual or DSG gearboxes. It reaches 0-100kmph in just 6.7 seconds, and its top speed is restricted electronically to 250kmph. While this is all the information that performance aficionados will ever need, hold up - this car is much more than this.

The Skoda Octavia RS comes with a three-spoke, flat-bottom steering wheel with red, double-stitched leather upholstery, 10-colour ambient lighting system, a frankly massive 590 litres of boot space, and the standard spacious interiors and comfortable seating that you get with the regular Octavia. What makes it important is that the Octavia RS will be the smartest car on Indian roads when it launches this month.

The Skoda Octavia RS will bring Lane Keeping and Departure As-

sistance, Blind Spot Monitoring, Rear and Front Traffic Assistance, and Handsfree Parking. Alongside, this is the first time that Skoda is bringing its top-of-the-line infotainment system, Columbus, to India. This gets integrated 4G LTE connectivity, a built-in hard drive for infotainment, and a massive 9.2-inch display. The instrument cluster also gets a multi-colour MID, and as an overall package, there will truly be no competitor, at least for the moment, when the Skoda Octavia RS launches in India soon.

What makes it super important, and worthy of a slot here? The Skoda Octavia RS is expected to be priced well within the Rs. 30 lac price point. For that money, you get the most powerful engine that money can buy, a luxury saloon with oodles of comfort, a massive boot to go camping, and intelligent computers that give advanced driving assistance.

In short, the Skoda Octavia RS is an incredibly mature proposition, one that we think will set a precedent for other high performance cars in India.

MERCEDES-AMG GT-R

The 'Beast of the Green Hell' is as different from the Octavia RS as you can think. For one, it certainly will turn your head even if you aren't a car fanatic, and more importantly, it is how full-bred performance cars are meant to be.

A sleek chassis, two sport seats designed to hug you in place through ludicrously fast corners, a 585bhp biturbo V8 engine that also produces 700Nm of torque, and every single

element that screams "speed!" in every possible way is what the AMG GT-R is all about. You get premium microfibre inside the two-seater cabin - on the armrest, on the dash, and even on the sport steering wheel. The V-shaped central column is clad in piano black finish, with eight evenly spaced circular buttons or toggles controlling everything - from ignition, driving modes (it obviously gets a 'Race' mode), traction control, suspension height, manual dynamics configurator, and even a volume button that seems to wonder, "what am I even doing here?"

Coupled with the fluid aerodynamics, the ruthless top speed of 318kmph and 0-100kmph timing of 3.6 seconds, the Mercedes-AMG GT-R also gets the complete COMAND infotainment system, that allows you to navigate, fire up Apple CarPlay and Android Auto, play music via the premium Burmester speakers, and even browse the Internet when you're not prancing down open, endless roads. It also gets a driver alert system that we're curious to try out soon, and a host of computers that provide a compass, a radar, lap timers, and temperature gauges to let you know of every single bit about itself.



At Rs. 2.23 crore, the Mercedes-AMG GT-R is a street-legal sports car that has very few of its brethren plying on Indian soil. The sheer fact that it is now in India is another tantamount proof of Indian car buyers gradually maturing. 